

Van Eyck

One of the first Flemish artists to sign his name on his work, Jan van Eyck (c.1390–1441) was also one of the first artists to use oil paints. Applying thin, translucent glazes with almost imperceptible brushmarks, he achieved an extraordinary level of detail in portraits and religious paintings. Little is known of his origins, but he was from a family of painters and probably came from Maaseik, near Maastricht. By c.1422, he was working in the Hague, already a master painter with a workshop and assistants. Three years later, he was in Bruges and Lille, painting for the Duke of Burgundy. He undertook diplomatic visits, including to Lisbon in 1428 to paint the portrait of the Duke's future wife.

Admired for his accuracy, clear colours and sharp observations, van Eyck worked for private patrons as well as at court. One of his most famous paintings is the 1434 *Arnolfini Portrait* – a vivid double portrait filled with symbolism. He made great impact on Italian Renaissance art and his precise style and techniques influenced northern European art for centuries.



Van Eyck, *The Arnolfini Portrait*, c.1434